

WRITING STYLE GUIDE

Let's make every word count and sound like Damco!

This guide is our pole star to foster a polished, cohesive presentation of Damco across all communication channels for enhanced readability and strengthened online presence.



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Our style guide ensures all our communications are clear, consistent, and reflect Damco's professional brand. This guide applies to everyone creating content for Damco, including content writers, editors, agencies, and marketing team members. It covers key areas such as tone, punctuation, and word usage, helping us deliver our message effectively across all platforms. By following these guidelines, we maintain a unified voice that inspires and engages our audience, building a trusted brand presence and credibility among potential and existing clients.

1. Brand Voice

Optimistic. Simple. Inspirational.

We are upbeat, resourceful, and friendly. We motivate and inspire readers by demonstrating a can-do attitude. We make customers believe in the possibilities of change, by acknowledging the challenges and focusing on solutions—without being delusional. We do not hyperbole or over-promise. We simplify things, explain them, and show the way forward.

2. Tone & Writing Style

We present the most difficult technology in the most straightforward language possible without dumbing down its power. Use: familiar tone, clarity, strong language with no fluff, and fillers. Our writing is crisp, simple, to the point. Principles of writing:

- Always use a neutral tone, avoiding bias in your writing—this includes avoiding the usage of gendered pronouns.
 - Original: When a user forgets his password, he can reset it using the password recovery tool.
Revised: When a user forgets their password, they can reset it using the password recovery tool.
 - Original: Every customer has his specific preferences.
Revised: All customers have their specific preferences.
- Never use a disparaging tone towards any technology, person, opinion, etc.
- Use simple, everyday words rather than complex terminology.
- Write in a style that is appropriate for your target audience.
- Write in a direct, conversational style (but avoid idioms, colloquialisms, and jargon).
- Always give context:
 - Original: Salesforce Content Management System (CMS) empowers teams with easy content delivery through its omni-channel feature.

Revised: Salesforce CMS empowers teams with easy content delivery.

- Be direct rather than complex, for instance:
 - Original: We're focused on providing high-quality knowledge transfer and a fulfilling session so you can learn and grow.
Revised: We're here to challenge and support you so you can get the most out of this session.
- Use active verbs, such as Innovate, Create, Develop, and Design.
- Strategic ordering of content:
 - Introduction
 - Headings
 - Batching or grouping of clear and crisp ideas
 - Add statistics/images/quotes (Flexible placement)
 - Conclusion
- Use American English- clean up the fluff, complex sentence structure, and extra words.
- Build a Narrative— One idea leading to another idea, with no idea standing alone.
 - Word Usage Original: Mentioned here are some of the industries where data cleaning plays a vital role.
Revised: Data cleaning is vital for these Industries.
 - Original: Take the case in point
Revised: Case in point

3. Word Usage

- Jargon: Let's avoid jargon wherever possible, such as, Disrupt, Unicorn, Game-Changer, and Cutting-Edge.
- Buzzwords/Slangs: They have a short shelf-life. Today's hot buzzword is tomorrow's embarrassing anachronism, so avoid using them.
 - Original: The code did not work anymore. It was all jacked up.
Revised: That code did not work anymore because of the old browser that doesn't support the classes.
- Words that do not add value and should be avoided in formal writings- 'Thinking outside the box', 'Core Competency', 'For all intents and purposes', 'Actionable', 'Giving 110%', 'Low-hanging Fruit', 'Drill Down', etc.
- Clichés: Avoid using cliches, as they are meaningless and add distaste to the content.
Example:

- Salesforce is the best platform with great features.
- Numbers: 1-9: Spell out the number; 10,10+: Use numerical.

4. Casing

- Always capitalize proper nouns, including author names and initials.
- When capitalizing titles, capitalize both words in a hyphenated compound word: Natural-Born Cyborgs.
- Don't capitalize the important words in the running sentence.
- Capitalize Damco's solutions and offerings: LoansNeo, Damco Startup Studio
- Capitalize the first word after a dash or colon. Example:
 - Defining Film Rhetoric: The Case of Hitchcock's Vertigo.
- All words in the title shall have the first letter in uppercase except the minor words (connectors, articles, prepositions, conjunctions – 4 characters or less - such as: for, an, with, the, etc.). Examples:
 - Dedicated Developers for Startups to Scale Technology Projects
 - Gain Improved Efficiency with Damco's Technology Services

5. Punctuations

- Contractions: Contractions are informal and should not be used in titles at all. You can use contractions in between the sentences when necessary, however overuse should be avoided. For example:
 - I'm for I am, You're for You are.
- Commas: Use Oxford or serial comma (apply a comma before 'and'). For example:
 - The solution helped the client leverage real-time data, improve efficiency, and reduce operational costs.
- Periods:
 - A Period goes inside the closing quotation mark at the end of a sentence.
 - Use in pointers that have complete sentences.
 - Do not use with incomplete sentences.
- Usage of Bullet Points:
 - Main Points: Roman numbers: I, II, III
 - Subheads: Bullets: •
 - Pointers: •
 - Sub-subheads: ►

- Semicolon: Use a semicolon if two or more clauses grammatically complete a compound sentence and are not joined by a conjunction.
- Colons:
 - Colons can introduce a bulleted list using a full sentence followed by a colon.
 - Use a capital letter if the first sentence introduces a quotation. Example: You would do well to remember the old saying: The early bird catches the worm.
 - When a colon introduces a list of things, do not capitalize the first word after the colon unless it is a proper noun. Example: The tech startup's product lineup consists of three main offerings: mobile app development, website design, and ecommerce solutions.

6. Paragraph

- Conciseness and crispiness: Remove unnecessary phrases, tautological expressions, redundancies, wordy constructions. Example:
 - Original: Our company specializes in providing a wide range of different IT services for businesses of all sizes.
Revised: Our company specializes in providing comprehensive IT services for businesses of all sizes.
 - Original: In order to effectively optimize your IT infrastructure, it is imperative that you conduct a thorough analysis of your current systems and identify areas for improvement.
Revised: To optimize your IT infrastructure effectively, conduct a thorough analysis of your current systems and identify areas for improvement.
 - Original: The main objective of this project is to deliver high-quality results that meet the specific needs and requirements of our clients.
Revised: The project aims to deliver high-quality results tailored to our clients' needs and requirements.
 - Original: For the purpose of enhancing productivity and efficiency, it is recommended that you adopt our latest software updates.
Revised: To enhance productivity and efficiency, adopt our latest software updates.
- Avoid adverbs that don't add value, such as 'extremely', 'very', 'definitely', etc.
- Strong sentence structures. Eliminating "you can" and 'there is/are/were' sentences can make your writing more direct and assertive. Instead of stating what the reader can do, simply present the action or capability itself. Example:
 - Original: You can install various plugins to enhance your development environment.
Revised: Install various plugins to enhance your development environment.
- Spacing between lines: 1.0
- Spacing between paragraphs: 1 Enter

- **Appropriate Length:** You may lose a reader's attention if your paragraphs are too long. Ideally, a paragraph should be 100 to 200 words long or be no more than five or six sentences. It should also have at least three sentences.
- **One-thought-focused and consistent content.**
- **Colloquialisms and clichés:** Things that have been said many times already, avoid using them as they add distaste to the content.
- **Always mention the source of images, quotations, stats, statements.**
- **Use double quotes while quoting someone.**
- **Follow the submission guidelines while pushing a piece for publication.**

7. Active Voice

Use active voice. Always mention who did the action to turn passive into active. For example:

- **Passive:** The code for the new application was written.
- **Active:** The software developer wrote the code for the new application.

8. Hyphens

- Only use hyphens for adjectives and not nouns. Example:
 - The company provides cutting-edge technology solutions.But not here:
The company provides technology solutions that are cutting edge.
- You do not need to use hyphen if the first word ends with 'ly'. Example: newly found solution.
- Words like ecommerce can be written differently in widely accepted formats such as e-commerce, eCommerce. However, to maintain consistency, we should stick to ecommerce/Ecommerce.

9. Dashes

- Use 'em dash' (—) to set off additional information in the structure of sentence. Do not use word spacing on either side of an em dash. The HTML code for an em dash is `—`. Example:
 - The information in your spreadsheet—numbers, formulas, and text—is stored in cells.
- The 'en dash' (–) is used primarily to indicate a range of numbers such as inclusive values, dates, or pages. The HTML code for an en dash is `–`. Example:
 - 2020–2024.

10. Parallelism

Parallelism is about using the same structure for similar elements in a sentence. This tactic makes writing clear, easy to read, and engaging. When listing items, comparing ideas, or presenting information, ensure all parts of your sentence follow the same grammatical pattern. Examples:

- Original: Our software improves efficiency, reduces costs, and it helps to streamline processes.

Explanation: The elements are not in the same grammatical form, causing a disruption in flow.

Revised: Our software improves efficiency, reduces costs, and streamlines processes.

Explanation: Each verb phrase is in the same form, making the sentence smooth and balanced.

- Original: The platform offers scalability, reliability, and is secure.

Explanation: The items listed are not parallel. "Scalability" and "reliability" are nouns, while "is secure" is a verb phrase.

Revised: The platform offers scalability, reliability, and security.

Explanation: Each item is a noun, ensuring the list is parallel.

11. First-Person, Second-Person, Third-Person Perspectives

- In developing case studies, success stories, website content or SME blogs, the choice between first-person, second-person, or third-person perspective should be consistent throughout the content. Avoid mixing these perspectives in any one content format. This ensures clarity and coherence in our storytelling while maintaining a tone that resonates with our audience.

For SME blogs, when an SME is sharing their personal experiences or insights, use the first-person perspective to create a personal connection with the audience. Example:

- In my experience, integrating AI into business processes can significantly improve efficiency.
- Employing a third-person perspective in case studies—using terms like "the client," "the company," or specific names, lends objectivity and credibility to the narrative. This perspective puts emphasis on providing informative content (company's achievements, experiences, and expertise) while outlining broad industry trends without overtly promoting our services. A first-person approach is best avoided as we don't want "corporate pride" to diminish the selling power of customer stories. Examples:
 - Original: Our team developed unique dashboards and tailored reports for different user categories as per their requirements and usability.
 - Revised: The team developed unique dashboards and tailored reports for different user categories as per their requirements and usability.

- Original: With a fresh perspective, our team decided to reimagine the data landscape.
Revised: With a fresh perspective, the team decided to reimagine the data landscape.
- For articulating B2B services, products, and solutions on a website, both third-person and second-person perspectives can be used effectively, depending on the context and desired tone. Examples:
 - Original (Mixed perspectives): Empowering you with our future-ready AI-based mobile and web applications to offer improved and intuitive user experience.
Revised (Second-person perspective): Offer improved and intuitive user experiences with future-ready AI-based mobile and web applications.
 - Original (Mixed perspectives): Our Machine Learning development services help you automate business processes and perform advanced data analytics.
Revised (Third-person perspective): Damco offers Machine Learning development services that help you automate business processes and perform advanced data analytics.
 - Original: One challenge that clients often bring to us is the question of building decision systems.
Revised: One challenge that clients often bring to Damco is the question of decision systems.

12. Usage of Abbreviations

- When introducing an abbreviation for the first time, ensure clarity by providing the full term followed by the abbreviation in parentheses. Example:
 - Customer Relationship Management (CRM) software is essential for managing client interactions.
- Utilize widely recognized abbreviations commonly accepted within the IT industry to streamline communication. For instance, "API" for Application Programming Interface and "IoT" for Internet of Things.
- Once an abbreviation is established, continue using it consistently for subsequent references to the same term.

13. A Focus on the Customer

- Engaging with our customers in a friendly and approachable manner, while maintaining clarity and readiness to assist, demonstrates our dedication towards customer success. A few key elements of writing can help in achieving that. Examples:
 - Get to the point. Begin with the main message, highlight essential information prominently, and ensure clear guidance for decision-making.
 - Adopt a conversational tone. Use optimistic language and tone. Use short sentences and sentence-style capitalization for a conversational feel.

- Embrace simplicity. Break down content into manageable portions, provide clear step-by-step instructions, and add layers of information as necessary. Choose concise sentences for easy readability, eliminating any redundant words.

14. Accessibility

- Damco is dedicated to making products, services, and content accessible to all. Content should be designed to support users with disabilities and various input methods, including keyboards, mice, touch screens, and voice. Here are some guidelines to get you started:
- Put key information near the beginning of the content.
- Write link text that is meaningful but brief.
- Do not use phrases such as “click here.” They are bad for accessibility and hurt usage of screen readers. Screen readers will collate a list of all hyperlinks on a website page and read them out so readers can click on the ones that would give them the information they need. So, use links that can stand alone in a list by replacing mechanical words with actions. Example:
 - Write ‘Click to view AI in Claims Settlement Demo’ instead of ‘Click Here or Click Demo’. Hyperlink all the words to make it sound useful to a diversely abled reader.
- Keep sentence structure simple. Try to limit sentences to one clause. Individuals who have language difficulties, non-native English speakers, and some people who are deaf or hard of hearing may have difficulty understanding longer, complicated sentences.
- Always provide alternative text (Alt text) for elements that are not text, including graphics, audio, and video. Ensure Alt text is helpful, effective, and concise while ensuring it’s no longer than a sentence or two.

For example, if it is a bar chart showing object-wise info about monthly sales, a mere description such as ‘January Hardware Sales’ won’t be useful to people with visual impairment. Try to be as descriptive about the subject, setting, interactions and other relevant information as possible. Example: The pie chart shows January Hardware Sales in percentage: Motherboard 37%, DDR: 25%, Graphic Cards 16%, HDD: 12%, and Servers 10%.

Microsoft 365 provides tools to enhance alt text for better content accessibility:

1. **Accessibility Checker:** Reviews visual content and suggests improvements.
2. **Automatic Alt Text Generator:** Creates alt text automatically.
3. **Manual Alt Text Editor:** Allows manual alt text editing.

To use the Accessibility Checker:

1. Go to the Review tab and select Check Accessibility.
2. In the Accessibility pane, view issues under Inspection Results.
3. Select any flagged issue to see recommended actions.

For those interested in more details, they can visit [W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines \(WCAG\)](#)

15. More Questions?

If you still have questions or something is missing that you want to discuss, feel free to reach out to: samars@damcogroup.com